Multiple Subdivisions

H 1090

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A. Background

As of July 2018, proposals for new "multiple" subdivisions stopped being accepted and individual strings that formerly would have been authorized by a multiple are individually proposed and established. Also in 2018, the Policy and Standards Division (now the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division) began a project to separately establish each valid heading string that was created based on a multiple subdivision and to cancel the multiple subdivisions. Existing multiple subdivisions remain valid for use until they have been cancelled.

This instruction sheet defines "multiple" subdivisions and describes the procedures for assigning headings under which multiple subdivisions have been established.

A "multiple" subdivision is a subdivision in the subject authority file that incorporates bracketed terms, generally followed by the word "etc." or an ellipsis. This device is used to suggest the creation of similar subdivisions under the heading in question. The presence of a multiple subdivision under a heading in the subject authority file automatically gives free-floating status to analogous subdivisions under the same heading, and, if the heading is a pattern heading, under those headings that it controls.

Examples:

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World War, 1939-1945--Personal narratives, American, [French, German, etc.]

Subject headings--Aeronautics, [Education, Latin America, Law, etc.]

Names, Personal--Scottish, [Spanish, Welsh, etc.]
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Some subdivisions used under name headings, though not actually established under any heading in the subject authority file, also function as multiple subdivisions, in that not only the subdivision itself, but also the bracketed element, may be assigned on a free-floating basis.

Examples:

[name of person]--Translations into French, [German, etc.]

[name of corporate body]--Fire, [date]

[place]–Foreign public opinion, British, [French, Italian, etc.]

The equivalent of a multiple subdivision appears in some instances in the subject authority file in the form of an instructional scope note that allows for free-floating subdivision of the heading as described and illustrated in the note.

Example:

Solar eclipses

Subdivided by date, e.g. Solar eclipses–1854.

Note: The subject authority file previously included main headings incorporating bracketed terms followed by the word "etc.", for example, *__Coins, Arab, [Austrian, French, etc.]__*. These were called "multiple headings" and served to suggest the creation of similar headings. Until 1981, individual headings controlled by a multiple heading were not printed in Library of Congress Subject Headings and were therefore not represented by individual authority records in the subject authority file. That practice was discontinued with the introduction of AACR2 in 1981. Individual authority records were then created for each heading that was needed for AACR2 cataloging that would formerly have been authorized by the authority record for a multiple heading. In 1990 all multiple headings were deleted from the subject authority file. Individual authority records were created for those headings formerly represented by a multiple that had been assigned by the Library of Congress to bibliographic records in the MARC database.

B. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Multiple subdivision: subdivision in the subject authority file that incorporates bracketed terms, generally followed by the word "etc." or an ellipsis.

D. Assigning headings with established multiple subdivisions

Once a multiple subdivision (or its equivalent, as described in the Background statement above) has been established under a heading, formulate and assign any subdivision falling within the scope illustrated by the multiple subdivision as a free-floating subdivision under that heading, or, if it is a pattern heading, under any heading that it controls.

Note: It is usually necessary, when assigning a free-floating subdivision of this type, to assign at least one additional heading to the work being cataloged, bringing out the topic named in the subdivision.

Examples:

Title: The best name book in the whole wide world.

650 #0 $a Names, Personal $x English.

(Authorized by: Names, Personal–Scottish, [Spanish, Welsh, etc.])

650 #0 $a English language $x Etymology $x Names.

Title: Washington on trial : the people of Cuba vs. the government of the United States of America.

651 #0 $a Cuba $x Claims vs. United States.

(Authorized by: --Claims vs. …)

E. LC practice for form subdivisions

Following guidance in H 1075, LC catalogers should not assign multiple subdivisions that are also form subdivisions. LC catalogers should instead assign appropriate LC Genre/Form Terms. If it is also necessary to indicate the intended audience, LC catalogers should assign LC Demographic Group Terms (LCDGT). Catalogers at institutions external to LC may use the multiple subdivisions that are also form subdivisions in accordance with their own institutional policies.

Examples:

LC practice:

Title: Amerikanische Stücke.

[The title is a collection of works by American dramatists, translated into German.]

650 #0 $a American drama.

385 ## $a German speakers $2 lcdgt

[Not $v Translations into German]

Title: 1900 census by the United States of America of Richland County, Illinois.

651 #0 $a Richland County (Ill.) $x Census, 1900.

651 #0 $a United States $x Census, 1900.

655 #7 $a Census data. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Registers (Lists) $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Genealogical tables. $2 lcgft

[Not $v Census, 1900]

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